

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



SOUTH ASIAN ASSOCIATION FOR REGIONAL
COOPERATION (SAARC) - 1

MODULE - 57

UNDERSTANDING SOUTH ASIA

- 1 South Asia is a region **geographically made distinct by the Himalayas** in the north and the three water bodies in the South- Arabian Sea, Bay of Bengal and Indian Ocean.
- 2 It includes **Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka.**
- 3 It often includes Afghanistan and Myanmar as well.
- 4 They **comprise 3% of the world area and roughly 21% of the world's population**

- 5 These countries have had colonial past and had been historically aligned to each other.



UNDERSTANDING SOUTH ASIA

- 6 In the post independence period, the countries of South Asia have been troubled with problems relating to underdevelopment, border issues, water sharing disputes, ethnic problems; to name a few.
- 7 The countries are asymmetrical in size, population, in access to natural resources, levels of literacy and political consciousness among citizens.
- 8 The South Asian countries had been suffering from high level of distrust, rivalry and mutual suspicion.
- 9 Wars of 1965 and 1971 between India and Pakistan, liberation of Bangladesh from Pakistan in 1971, Maoist problems of Nepal and ethnic problems of Sri Lanka caused loss of life and property, refugee problems and regional instability



IDEA OF REGIONAL COOPERATION

- 1 By 1980s, there was an understanding and need among the nations of South Asia, that they could develop and grow individually, if they cooperated and co-existed multilaterally.
- 2 Taking lessons of the economic development and regional integration from European Union, people of South Asia felt that that the region could prosper if the nations of the region agreed to cooperate with each other.
- 3 The idea of regional cooperation in South Asia was first raised in 1980.

- 4 The countries of South Asia agreed to create a platform to enhance a spirit of friendship, trust and mutual understanding among the nation states.



IDEA OF REGIONAL COOPERATION

- 5 The idea was to focus on similarities and identify common areas of understanding.
- 6 South Asia was the birthplace of several religions including Hinduism, Buddhism and Jainism; had a large number of Muslim and Christian population.
- 7 The people of this region were linguistically, socially and culturally distinct from the rest of the world. Moreover, democracy was getting accepted as a norm in South Asia.



SOUTH ASIAN COOPERATION

- 1 In 1985, the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation was established and its Charter was approved
- 2 It started with seven member states- Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka.
- 3 In 2007 Afghanistan became a member of SAARC at the 14th SAARC summit in India.
- 4 There are eight observer status nations of SAARC- China, European Union, Iran, Japan, South Korea, Mauritius, Myanmar and United States of America.

- 5 The Heads of States of the SAARC nations are expected to meet annually.



VISION OF SAARC

1 SAARC aims to promote the welfare of the people of South Asia and improve their quality of life through accelerated growth, social progress and cultural development of the region.

2 They understand the need for joint actions in enhancing political and economic systems and cultural traditions.

3 The organisation is based on five principles: sovereign equality, territorial integrity, political independence, non-interference in internal matters of members states and mutual benefit.

4 They abide by the principles of United Nations Charter and Non-Alignment.



OBJECTIVES OF SAARC

The objectives of SAARC were decided as:

- 1 To promote the welfare of the peoples of South Asia and to improve their quality of life.
- 2 To accelerate economic growth, social progress and cultural development in the region.
- 3 To provide all individuals with the opportunity to live in dignity and to realise their full potentials.
- 4 To promote and strengthen collective self-reliance among the countries of South Asia
- 5 To contribute to mutual trust, understanding and appreciation of one another's problems.



OBJECTIVES OF SAARC

- 6** To promote active collaboration and mutual assistance in the economic, social, cultural, technical and scientific fields.
- 7** To strengthen cooperation with other developing countries.
- 8** To strengthen cooperation among themselves in international forums on matters of common interests.
- 9** To cooperate with international and regional organisations with similar aims and purposes.



AGREEMENTS UNDER SAARC

The important agreements which SAARC has come up with are as following-

- 1 SAARC has launched the South Asia Free Trade Agreement (SAFTA) in 2006. The objective of SAFTA is to reduce custom duties on all traded goods to zero by the year 2016.
- 2 The framework agreement for energy cooperation in South Asian region was also agreed upon. This agreement would focus on electricity supply in the region.

COUNTRIES IN SAFTA

	Afghanistan		the Maldives
	Bangladesh		Nepal
	Bhutan		Pakistan
	India		Sri Lanka

AGREEMENTS UNDER SAARC

The important agreements which SAARC has come up with are as following-

- 3 The organisation has also come up with Visa exemption scheme for a specific category of dignitaries.
- 4 There are also regional railways development scheme, motor vehicle scheme etc. going on in the organisation.
- 5 The South Asia satellite (SAS) was built by India and launched in May, 2017 from Sriharikota in Andhra Pradesh.

- 6 The advanced space technology is expected to bring growth and prosperity for the people of South Asia



OBSERVERS OF SAARC

States with observer status include Australia, China, the European Union, Iran, Japan, Mauritius Myanmar, South Korea and the United States.

INSTITUTIONS OF SAARC

1. Secretariat
2. Council of Ministers
3. Standing Committee
4. SAARC Development Fund
5. South Asian University
6. SAARC Arbitration Council



INSTITUTIONS OF SAARC

1. SECRETARIAT

- 1 SAARC has a Secretariat based in Kathmandu, Nepal.
- 2 The Secretariat coordinates and monitors implementation of activities; as well as acts as a medium of communication between the organisation and its member states.
- 3 It also serves as a point of contact with other regional organisations.
- 4 It is to be headed by a Secretary-General.
- 5 Decisions at all levels of SAARC are taken based on unanimity. All bilateral and contentious issues are excluded from the discussions in the association



INSTITUTIONS OF SAARC

2. COUNCIL OF MINISTERS

1 SAARC consists of a Council of Ministers which consist of foreign ministers of the member states.

- 2 Their functions include:
- Policy formulation
 - Review of the current work of the organisation
 - Identifying and taking decisions on newer areas of cooperation
 - Establishing new mechanisms if necessary
 - Deciding on matters of general interest of the organisation



INSTITUTIONS OF SAARC

3. STANDING COMMITTEE

- 1 The Standing Committee of SAARC comprises of Foreign Secretaries of the member nations.
- 2 Their functions include:
 - Monitoring and coordinating programs of cooperation
 - Approving projects and programs and identifying methods of financing them
 - Mobilisation of resources
 - Identifying newer areas of cooperation
 - Submitting periodic reports to Council of Ministers.



INSTITUTIONS OF SAARC

4. SAARC DEVELOPMENT FUND

- 1 The SAARC development fund was established at the 13th SAARC summit held in Dhaka in 2005.
- 2 It is a comprehensive mechanism for funding social, economic and infrastructure projects and initiatives.
- 3 It is governed by a board consisting of members from Ministry of Finance of the member nations.

- 4 It has a Secretariat who funds project-based collaboration.



WE EXPRESS OUR
SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588